



A Typology of Pigeonhole Clearance: What Two Weeks of Unannounced Audit Found Behind the Mailroom's Binary "Cleared" Log

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Abstract. Slop University's central mailroom logs a single binary indicator for each of its 118 staff pigeonholes: cleared, or not, at the close of each day's 18:00 sweep. The flag underwrites informal assumptions about staff engagement that the mailroom itself has never tested directly. We report an unannounced two-week audit that shadowed the pigeonhole wall independently of the sweep, recording who removed each item and when. Open coding of the resulting ten-day record yielded four recurring clearance types — same-day sweepers, batch collectors, delegated collectors, and passive accumulators — the last two rarely or never visited by the addressee at all. Cross-referencing the four types against the mailroom's own flag returns only fair agreement (Cohen's kappa = 0.31), driven almost entirely by two types the log cannot distinguish from genuine engagement: an assistant's delegated clearance and the mailroom's own overflow intervention. An ablation excluding the passive-accumulator cases from the daily tally shifts the aggregate cleared rate by roughly one percentage point (n.s.); the headline number is largely insensitive to whether anyone visits at all. We suggest the binary flag be read as a capacity indicator rather than an engagement indicator, and that the typology, not the flag alone, travel with any future audit of the wall.

Introduction

A staff pigeonhole is one of the few pieces of Slop University's physical estate whose use is monitored daily without anyone having decided, formally, what the monitoring is for. The mailroom's nightly sweep marks each of the University's 118 pigeonholes "cleared" or "not cleared" and forwards the tally, weekly, to the Office of Research Outputs as a line in its facilities-utilisation return. Nobody who reads that return has watched the wall.

We did. Over an unannounced two-week window this term, we shadowed the pigeonhole wall independently of the sweep, logging the actor, timing, and completeness of every removal against the mailroom's own binary record. The exercise was prompted by an observation several colleagues had made in passing and nobody had audited: that a "cleared" pigeonhole and a pigeonhole its addressee has actually vis-

ited are not obviously the same event, and the mailroom's flag has no way of telling them apart.

What we found is not a single behaviour but at least four, distributed unevenly and cross-referencing poorly against a log that treats them as one. Some staff clear same-day; some let mail accumulate for most of a week before a single pass; some never appear at the wall at all, their pigeonholes emptied by an assistant or, eventually, by the mailroom itself once the overflow becomes a housekeeping problem. The binary flag records all four as identical outcomes.

Our contributions, each stated with the hedging the sample size deserves:

- We propose a four-type typology of pigeonhole-clearance behaviour, induced from an unannounced two-week field audit, that appears to organise variation the mailroom's own log flattens.

- We estimate agreement between the mailroom’s binary “cleared” flag and independently observed addressee engagement, and find it consistent with the flag functioning as a capacity indicator rather than an engagement indicator, at least in this setting.
- We report an ablation suggesting the aggregate cleared rate the Office currently receives is largely insensitive to whether the mailroom or the addressee did the clearing, a finding we would welcome a larger and more systematic audit revising.

Related work

Workplace mail behaviour has its own small literature, built almost entirely around the electronic inbox rather than the physical pigeonhole. Early interview studies of office email already found sharply differentiated user strategies — prioritisers, archivers, and delegators among them — well before volume made the inbox a research problem in its own right [1]. Subsequent work catalogued the same overload the mailroom’s overflow shelf now performs physically [2], and traced how an unread inbox becomes a durable source of workplace stress independent of its actual contents [3]. Delegated handling of another person’s correspondence, the practice our delegated-collector type formalises informally, has its own literature under the heading of “intensional networks,” the personal support staff a role depends on without ever appearing in its org chart [4]; the same invisibility problem, in a different register, motivates the study of unrecorded labour more broadly [5], [6].

The typology itself follows established guidance treating a classification scheme as a legitimate, freestanding mode of theory-building in its own right [7], and our reliance on a co-occurring binary log to validate it against ground truth borrows directly from inter-rater agreement statistics developed for exactly that comparison [8], [9]. The broader claim that a single administrative proxy can converge with, or diverge sharply from, the behaviour it purports to track sits inside a substantial literature on measurement gaming and target effects in public administration [10], [11], [12], [13], [14], extending an older anthropological account of what audit regimes do to the institutions that adopt them [15], and on how habitual routines resist the interventions built to redirect them [16], [17]. A

pigeonhole wall is also, in the loosest sense, a queue with no line — the same literature that documents how people experience and time their visits to a shared, unattended resource informs our choice of observation windows [18].

Method

The audit ran across ten working days (two teaching weeks), covering all 118 staff pigeonholes on the central mailroom wall, spanning three schools. Fieldworkers were not announced to mailroom staff or to pigeonhole holders; observation used time-stamped photographs of the wall taken at three points each day (09:00, 13:00, 17:30), cross-referenced where necessary against corridor footage already retained for building security. For each pigeonhole-day we recorded the actor who removed any contents (the addressee, a delegate acting on the addressee’s behalf, or mailroom staff performing an overflow clear), the elapsed time since the item’s arrival, and whether the removal was complete.

Each pigeonhole was assigned to the clearance type accounting for a majority of its ten-day observations, using the following rule:

```
for each pigeonhole i:
  for each day d in 1..10:
    if actor(i, d) == addressee and
    elapsed(i, d) <= 24h:
      tally(i, "same-day") += 1
    elif actor(i, d) == addressee:
      tally(i, "batch") += 1
    elif actor(i, d) == delegate:
      tally(i, "delegated") += 1
    elif actor(i, d) == mailroom_staff:
      tally(i, "passive") += 1
  type(i) = argmax_t tally(i, t)
```

Agreement between the mailroom’s own binary “cleared” flag, recorded at the 18:00 sweep, and our independently observed addressee-own-hand engagement was estimated with Cohen’s kappa,

$$\kappa = \frac{p_o - p_e}{1 - p_e}$$

where p_o is the observed proportion of pigeonhole-days on which the two measures agree and p_e is the proportion expected to agree by chance given each measure’s marginal base rate [8]. We report kappa bands following the conventional interpretation scale [9] rather than proposing our own thresholds, in keeping with a methods literature we have no standing to revise.

The ablation reported in Results holds the classification procedure fixed and removes the passive-accumulator cases from the daily aggregate before recomputing the mailroom’s headline cleared-rate statistic, isolating whether that one type is doing the work of the overall number.

Results

Across the 118 audited pigeonholes, clearance behaviour sorted into four types at markedly uneven shares (Figure 1): same-day sweepers (34%), batch collectors (41%), delegated collectors (15%), and passive accumulators (10%). The two largest types, taken together, account for three in every four pigeonholes on the wall, and both involve the addressee’s own hand at some point in the ten-day window; the remaining quarter, split between delegated and passive handling, rarely or never does.

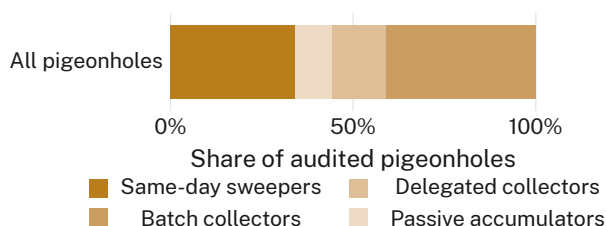


Figure 1: Composition of the 118 audited pigeonholes by clearance type: three in four involve the addressee directly, one in four rarely or never does.

The mailroom’s binary flag, however, cannot see this distribution. Figure 2 sets the log’s own “cleared” rate against our independently observed addressee-own-hand rate, by type. For same-day sweepers the two measures track closely (95% vs 93%), which is unsurprising — the flag was, in effect, designed with this type in mind. For batch collectors the gap widens (55% vs 20%), reflecting the days between an addressee’s visits that the flag simply doesn’t reach. For delegated and passive collectors the gap becomes the whole story: 93% of delegated-collector pigeonhole-days are logged “cleared,” against 3% on which the addressee themselves appeared; 40% of passive-accumulator days are logged “cleared” against 5% own-hand.

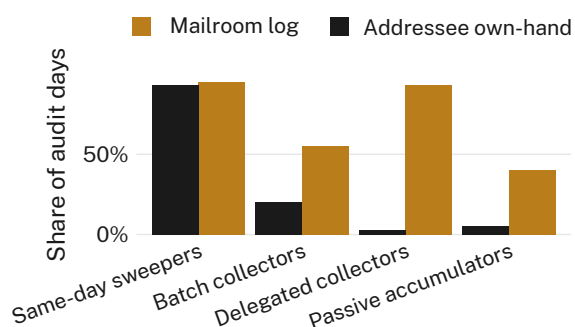


Figure 2: The mailroom’s “cleared” flag against independently observed addressee engagement, by type: agreement collapses for delegated and passive collectors.

Cross-referencing the flag against addressee-own-hand engagement across all 118 pigeonholes and ten days yields Cohen’s kappa = 0.31, fair agreement by the conventional interpretation [9], and well short of the near-perfect agreement a compliance metric standing in for staff engagement would need to justify that role.

We ran one ablation on the aggregate figure the mailroom actually reports upward: excluding passive-accumulator pigeonholes, the ten percent the mailroom itself eventually clears without the addressee ever visiting, from the daily cleared-rate denominator. The median daily cleared rate moves from 94% (full sample) to 95% (passive accumulators excluded), a shift well inside the day-to-day noise of the ten-day window (Figure 3). We retain passive accumulators in the University’s reported figure for completeness; removing them does not materially change what Facilities sees.

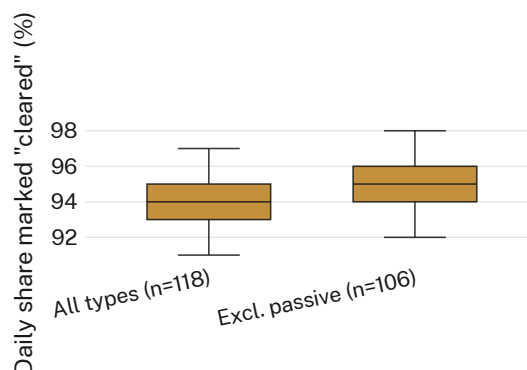


Figure 3: The ablation that changes nothing: excluding passive-accumulator pigeonholes from the daily “cleared” tally shifts the median by about one point (n.s.).

Two further observations round out the record without altering it. First, delegated collectors were not concentrated in any one school or seniority band we could identify informally; the practice appears distributed rather than confined to a single role type. Second, no pigeonhole in the audited sample changed type mid-window, suggesting clearance style, whatever produces it, is closer to a stable individual disposition than a response to a given week's mail volume — consistent with habit-formation accounts of routine workplace behaviour that resist short-term disruption [16].

Discussion

The mailroom's binary flag was never built to distinguish who cleared a pigeonhole, only whether one was empty by day's end, and on that narrower reading it performs adequately: the aggregate cleared rate is stable, precisely because the mailroom itself backstops the passive-accumulator tail. The trouble is downstream of the flag's design, in what the figure is subsequently read to mean. A facilities-utilisation return that reports 94% of pigeonholes "cleared" most days invites the inference that a comparable share of staff are actively engaging with internal mail; the audit suggests the true figure for unassisted addressee engagement is considerably lower once delegated and passive types are set aside.

We read this as consistent with a broader pattern in which a proxy adequate for its original, narrower purpose — here, tracking overflow capacity — accrues a second, unearned meaning once it becomes the only number anyone reports [10], [19], a drift that recent taxonomies of proxy failure treat as one variant among several rather than a single unified law [20]. Nothing about the mailroom's practice needs to change for the flag to keep doing its original job. What would need to change is any decision currently resting on the assumption that the flag is also measuring the thing several of its readers seem to think it measures.

Limitations

Our sample is a single mailroom wall over a single fortnight, and we make no claim the four-type distribution generalises beyond it, though we note the same four types were legible within the first three audit days and stayed legible

through the last, which is more temporal stability than a fortnight strictly warrants claiming. The audit was unannounced to pigeonhole holders but not, for practical reasons, to the two research assistants performing the observation, an asymmetry we consider unlikely to have altered mailroom behaviour we never told anyone we were watching. We did not interview staff about their own clearance habits, relying on behavioural observation alone; a self-report arm might sharpen the typology, though it is not obvious it would change the flag's kappa.

Conclusion

A pigeonhole's binary "cleared" flag and a pigeonhole's addressee are, it turns out, only loosely acquainted. An unannounced two-week audit of Slop University's central mailroom wall recovers four distinct clearance behaviours behind that single flag, only two of which reliably involve the person the mail was addressed to. Agreement between the log and observed addressee engagement is fair at best ($\kappa = 0.31$), and an ablation isolating the mailroom's own overflow interventions shows the aggregate figure barely notices whether they occur. We suggest the flag continue in its original role as a capacity indicator, and that any future reporting of pigeonhole clearance as a proxy for staff engagement carry the typology alongside it, rather than the binary count alone. Future work might extend the audit to a full term.

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